Internal Retrospective: Outfit7 Proof of Concept — Why It Stalled

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This is a short post-mortem on the Outfit7 engagement that we should probably document before we forget the details. Not an official retro — just my notes.

What We Were Asked to Do

Outfit7 came to us in July 2023 wanting a proof of concept for an internal HR knowledge assistant. Their HR team in Ljubljana (they have ~180 people there, total global headcount much larger) was dealing with a lot of repetitive questions from employees about benefits, PTO policies, onboarding processes, etc. Classic internal FAQ-bot use case. Budget was flexible — they mentioned "up to €20k for a PoC" in the first call.

What Happened

We ran a 3-week scoping phase (Anja and Luka on this). The documents were mostly in English, some in Slovenian, one or two in German — manageable. The technical side was straightforward: 40–60 documents, Chroma as a vector DB, Claude Haiku for generation (cost reasons), FastAPI + simple UI. Luka had a prototype running by week 4. It worked fine.

Then we hit the real problem: internal approvals at Outfit7.

Their parent company (Ekipa2, via the Chinese ownership structure — complicated) requires any third-party software that processes employee data to go through a security review that apparently takes 3–4 months. The Ljubljana HR lead (Maja Bergant) had not known this when she initiated the engagement. When she found out, she was more frustrated than we were.

We paused the project in September pending security review. By October it was clear this wasn't moving anywhere on their timeline. Maja left the company in early November (unrelated, she told us — I believe her). Her replacement has not contacted us.

Money

We invoiced for the scoping phase: €6,200. Paid without issue. The PoC development work (€4,800 we had informally committed to) was never formally contracted, so we absorbed it. Luka spent about 12 days on it. That's the real cost.

Lessons

1. **Always ask about third-party software approval processes before scoping tech work.** Sounds obvious. We didn't ask. This is now in our standard discovery questionnaire.
2. **Gaming/entertainment companies with complex ownership structures have compliance overhead that doesn't match their startup-y culture.** Outfit7 people act like a scrappy game studio. Their legal/security reality is a multinational corporation. These don't match.
3. **"Up to €20k for a PoC" is not a contracted budget.** We should have had a signed SOW before Luka started building. We didn't because Tine (me) said to move fast. Bad call.

Status

Project is effectively dead. I'm leaving it open in CRM for another 60 days in case Maja's replacement surfaces. If nothing by February 2024, we close it.

The Chroma/Haiku prototype Luka built is actually clean code and reasonably documented. We should extract it as a template for future small-corpus PoCs. Žiga — can you review and strip out the Outfit7-specific stuff?